



creating a cauldron-like atmosphere that was tough for even the seasoned batters to traverse.

Under the warm afternoon sun, tensions escalated as the spirited debutant, Rishabh Mishra, succeeded in unsettling Karnataka's wicketkeeper-batsman, S. Sharath. A volley of heated words transpired between the two, prompting the umpires to intervene as both teams made their way for tea.

Responding to the situation, the seasoned duo of Manish Pandey (left) and V. Vyshak showcased remarkable counterattacking skills, effectively silencing the Railways and compelling them to spread the field in an effort to protect the boundaries. The crowd swelled with each run scored by Karnataka, passionately rallying behind the former India international.

As Vyshak departed, leaving Karnataka in need of 29 runs, the atmosphere remained charged with

Nerves of steel: Manish Pandey (with bat) and V. Vyshak played crucial knocks to guide Karnataka to a thrilling one-wicket win over Railways. VIJAY SONEJI

anticipation. The chant of '*Do rupay ki Pepsi, Manish bhai sexy*' echoed through the stands near the dugout. Manish, in the dying moments of the day, treated the crowd to a masterful display of shot-making.

Amidst audible gasps and cheers, a moment of tension unfolded on the field and in the gallery when Manish and V. Koushik navigated a mix-up in the middle, surviving a couple of edges before ultimately guiding Karnataka to a hard-fought victory.

Anish Pathiyil

Local fervour

Once witness to Chetan Sharma's hat-trick in the 1987 World Cup against New Zealand, spectacles are now rare for the VCA Stadium at Civil Lines in Nagpur. Even international matches have been moved to the new stadium at Jamtha.

Washed up at its door and fallen out of the ranks in the Indian team, local boy Umesh Yadav — charting a comeback trail to the upper echelon — might not have matched the feat above, but it was fair consolation.

Also, to welcome the storied master, Chandrakant Pandit — once of its ranks, and now ushering a new domestic heavyweight in Madhya Pradesh — only elevated the occasion further.

Hence, no clarion call was needed for the Vidarbha faithful to bear witness to the team's Ranji Trophy semifinal against Madhya Pradesh.

From the solitary middle-tier stand at the Municipal Corporation End, the VCA Stadium at Civil Lines was rekindled to life.

Umesh stole the loudest cheers, unsurprisingly. The rhythmic stirring up, synchronised to perfection, growing louder as he loaded up to the popping crease, and bursting open at his leap and release made the 12th man for the home team. Extended periods away from the square, meant "Umesh, Umesh" chants reminded captain Akshay Wadkar that it was time to make a change to his bowling.

The sighting of Avesh Khan and Venkatesh Iyer — Indian team players, even if at the fringes, and though from the opposite camp — at the boundary rope inspired the crowd. Adulation was reserved for Himanshu Mantri too, who was granted a standing ovation for his hundred in the first innings.

The attendance was a welcome change from the usual sight of empty stands at Ranji Trophy games. As Vidarbha wrapped up the affair on the morning of the final day, it took a moment to appreciate the support. Up on their feet, the fans swarmed the players in their embrace, spurring them on for their showdown against heavyweight Mumbai.

Abhishek Saini

Delight for the fans: A packed VCA Stadium threw their weight behind a victorious Vidarbha team, especially Umesh Yadav, who scalped three wickets in its semi-final against Madhya Pradesh. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

